

DESIGNER

CHRISTIAN DIOR

French designer Christian Dior's revolutionary "New Look" dominated womenswear from the late 1940s to the mid-1950s. Suddenly, waists were cinched in and tiny, busts high and prominent, shoulders soft and sloping, and skirts longer than before and voluminous. Dior's hourglass look revived stiffened bodices and petticoats, and used lavish quantities of expensive fabric. After the plain, boxier styles of World War II, this return to extravagance and the femininity of the past was perplexing to some, but others found it refreshing and alluring.

In his earlier years Dior had studied political science and had also helped to run two art galleries, but in 1935 he began selling fashion illustrations to newspapers and to designers such as Robert Piguet. By 1938 he was Piguet's assistant designer. At Piguet's Dior produced round-hipped, narrowing *Amphora* dresses, which reappeared later. He attracted much attention with a *Café Anglais* outfit for Spring 1939, featuring a houndstooth wool dress with a tight-fitting top and full skirt.

Looking to the past

Dior's next fashion post (1941–46) was at the House of Lucien Lelong – first alongside fellow assistant Balmain, then as principal designer. Here, while making costumes for the film *Le Lit à Colonne* (1942), set in the later 1800s, Dior's research into period fashions and tailoring techniques fired his imagination.

Dior opened his own house in 1946, thanks to the backing of textile producer Marcel Boussac. His first collection, for Spring 1947 – one line named *Corolle* after its inverted petal shape and featuring the iconic "Bar" suit – was called the "New Look" by *Harper's Bazaar* editor Carmel Snow. So began ten

years in which the diligent, fastidious, and shyly modest Dior was at the fashion world's pinnacle, bringing Paris-centred haute couture back after a period of US-style ascendancy. Rita Hayworth, Margot Fonteyn, and Princess Margaret were among many glittering devotees, and in 1957 Dior accounted for over half of all Paris haute-couture sales.

Changing shapes

After a string of collections, Dior's Spring 1953 *Tulip* collection featured flowery colours and patterns, and a series of looser silhouettes. The "H" shape (1954) narrowed and flattened with an accent across the hips, while Spring 1955 saw "A-line" suits influenced by men's tailoring and flaring from the shoulder; Autumn's "Y-line" brought tapered skirts and emphasis on shoulders. Other style-setting trademarks included sumptuous evening dresses, dramatic "coolie" and "cartwheel" hats, ropes of pearls, stand-away collars, princess-line dresses, half-belts on jackets and coats, and stoles. Blue, grey, white, pink, and red were favourite colours. Oriental touches were seen in tunic dresses and cheongsams (straight dresses with stand-up collars and a side split). Dior's styles later loosened into forms such as the *vareuse* (pea coat).

After Dior died in 1957, his young assistant, Yves St Laurent, took the reins, followed by Marc Bohan, Gianfranco Ferré, John Galliano, Raf Simons, and Maria Grazia Chiuri. Dior's success stemmed in part from his brilliance at what today is known as marketing, and that flair for product promotion is as much his legacy as his New Look. While at the top for only about a decade, the influence of his still-thriving, multi-product global brand has been enormous, and he has been a major inspiration to designers from Christian Lacroix to the Marchesa label.



△ TRADEMARK STYLE

Dior was kind, conscientious, and loved by his employees. He is seen here in 1957 with one of his models, who wears a superbly styled Dior suit.



◁ DIOR FOR EVENING

A stunning take on the hobble skirt in gleaming satin, this model was presented at Dior's Autumn/Winter 1959 show. Self-fabric roses clutch the dress above the knees, creating a full, bloused effect.



TIMELINE

1905 Born in Granville, Normandy	1935 Starts career as a fashion illustrator	1938 Hired as Robert Piguet's assistant designer. Begins to develop Dior look	1941 Takes post at Lucien Lelong; later made principal designer	1946 Finds own fashion house in Paris	1947 Presents first collection, soon to be dubbed the "New Look"	1953 Launches <i>Tulip</i> collection, with floral patterns	1957 Dies at Montecatini, Italy	1959 John Galliano, first Englishman to run a French couture house, leaves Givenchy to become Dior's artistic director	1996 Dies at Montecatini, Italy	2012, 2016 Raf Simons becomes artistic director, followed by Maria Grazia Chiuri	2009 Galliano holds triumphant Spring/Summer show
○ 1900	○ 1930		○ 1940		○ 1950		○ 1990		○ 2000		